

To what extent was the Rodney King incident the main contributor for the LA riots?

Word Count: 2199 (Excluding headings)

Table of Contents

Investigation and Evaluation of Sources	3
Investigation	4
Reflection	8
Work Cited	9

Section 1: Identification and Evaluation of Sources

This internal assessment will investigate—*To what extent was the Rodney King incident the main contributor for the 1992 Los Angeles riots?* Despite activists and past legislation attempting to promote equity and impartiality in the United States, discrimination against African Americans continued to persist long after the civil rights movement of the mid-20th century. The LA Riots serve as a symbolic event in highlighting the endless struggle for black liberation and the persistence of injustices within African American communities.

The origin of the book, *“Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles”*¹, is valuable because it has been published by the Oxford University Press, and peer-reviewed by many historians such as James Cook who is an expert in the Social and Behavioral Sciences. Furthermore, the author herself, Janet Abu-Lughod, was a Sociology professor at the University of Massachusetts, making this book's origin significantly more credible and reliable. However, an apparent limitation of Professor Lughod's source is its reliance solely on secondary sources and the absence of firsthand experiential insights from her about the LA riots. This reliance on sources due to her lack of personal involvement hinders the depth of analysis and understanding of the riots comprehensively. Moreover, the content of the book provides insight into racism in America and how it led to various significant riots during the late 20th century. One of the values of Abu-Lughod's book is that she utilizes numerous primary sources of bars or pie graphs to highlight the concise economic catastrophes from numerous such as the estimated billion dollars losses from property damage. Hence, this data is especially important as it was created after the LA Riots and provides data validated through her professional sociological background. The purpose of this book is to disseminate it in areas of academia. This makes the book more valuable as its purpose is to provide creditable insight and knowledge into numerous riots that scholars may be unaware of.

Moreover, the *Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department* was a diligent investigation of the LAPD specifically after the Rodney King beating—developed from 1991-1998.² The commission report is valuable because it was created by Warren Christopher—the former United States Secretary of State. However, the length of time this report was created is a limitation because they had a short time period to deeply research decades of corrupt LAPD behaviors. The purpose of this report was to explicitly uncover the disingenuous and exploitative behaviors of the Los Angeles

¹ Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

² Christopher, Warren. *Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department*. N.p., DIANE Publishing Company, 1998.

Police Department to replace Chief Daryl Gates. This is a limitation as there is confirmation bias as the report predominately finds only the negative aspects of the LAPD and is influenced by a goal to find the knowledge that could effectively put Daryl Gates out of office—looking into more critical aspects of the LAPD³. Nevertheless, the purpose of this report is accomplished and makes the report valuable in uncovering numerous abusive and unethical behaviors that the LAPD did. The content of this report included the LAPD's extensive database of complaints, shootings, interviews, attorney case files, and statistical reports.⁴ Thus, this commission report is ultimately reliable as the resources that the committee had were substantial and relevant for this investigation.

³ Christopher, Warren. Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department. N.p., DIANE Publishing Company, 1998.

⁴ Christopher, Warren. Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department. N.p., DIANE Publishing Company, 1998.

Section 2: Investigation

On March 11, 1991, Rodney King was struck approximately fifty-six times by four Los Angeles Police Department officers.⁵ King would be hospitalized after having severe injuries to the skull and body. A year later on April 29, 1992, the Los Angeles Riots took place. This internal assessment investigates to what extent was the beating of Rodney King the main contributor to the LA riots and evaluates other factors that have led to the LA riots. Although tensions with LAPD and ethnic groups may have played a role in the events leading to the Los Angeles riots, it was ultimately the systemic discrepancies within the justice system that developed the most significant contribution.

The first contributor to the Los Angeles Riots was the lack of faith and tensions the black population had against the Los Angeles Police Department. According to Historian Anne Gray Fischer, this lack of faith in the LAPD and tensions towards aggressive police officers ultimately was orchestrated by the leadership of Daryl Gates because he'd often deployed officers in predominantly Black and Hispanic neighborhoods in South Los Angeles.⁶ Daryl Gates' administration was the Chief of the Los Angeles Police Department from 1978 to 1992 and often deployed SWAT units excessively.⁷ Moreover, both Assistant Chief officers who worked under Daryl Gates—Jesse Brewer and David Dotson—have openly testified that there had been a repetition of “excessive force” against underprivileged communities. However, even before the Rodney King incident, violence and aggression were a continuity within police units. For example, a decade before the beating of King—in 1982—James Mincey Jr, a young 20-year-old African-American man received a carotid choke hold from a white police officer which led to fatal neck injuries—causing neurological brain damage that led to his death.⁸ This demonstrates how tensions between Blacks and the LAPD accumulated from the past and the beating of Rodney King was only a catalyst to the LA riots. Furthermore, Daryl Gates further instigated tensions against the black population

⁵ LERMAN, STEVEN A. “From Rodney King to George Floyd.” *Newsweek Global*, vol. 176, no. 14, May 2021, pp. 30–31. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=7621425e-a530-3c8f-9d53-67b6e780336e.

⁶ Fischer, Anne Gray, *The Streets Belong to Us: Sex, Race, and Police Power from Segregation to Gentrification* (Chapel Hill, NC, 2022; online edn, North Carolina Scholarship Online, 18 May 2023), <https://doi.org/10.5149/northcarolina/9781469665047.001.0001>, accessed 6 Mar. 2024.

⁷ Woo, Elaine. “Daryl F. Gates dies at 83; innovative but controversial chief of the LAPD.” *Los Angeles Times*, 8 March 2014, <https://www.latimes.com/local/obituaries/la-me-daryl-gates17-2010apr17-story.html>. Accessed 29 August 2023.

⁸ Rainey, James. “Final Suit Over LAPD's Use of Chokehold Settled.” *Los Angeles Times*, 29 September 1993

as he openly and proudly admitted in 1982 that blacks would be choked to death more by police officers.⁹ This triggering response was insensitive towards the black community as they recently would just have James Mincey die from a chokehold.¹⁰ This demonstrates how there could have been a lack of faith in Daryl Gates as well as the entirety of the LAPD administration before the beating against Rodney King and serves to showcase how tensions between blacks and the LAPD were a catalyst to the LA riots. Moreover, *The 1998 Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department*—initiated by the Secretary of the State, Warren Christopher—highlights how between 1987 and 1991, almost 6,000 officers were reported for using unnecessary force, and the top 10% of officers contributed to more than 27.5% of excessive force.¹¹ Since police units were continuously violent, the beating of King was only one of many brutal incidents and highlights how the Los Angeles Riots sparked only after the Rodney King incident because the LAPD accumulated consistent violence against the black population. Ultimately, this demonstrates how the consistent violence from the LAPD and Daryl Gates' convoluted leadership somewhat contributed to the start of the 1992 Los Angeles Riots.

However, tensions between Asian and Black communities also contributed to the Los Angeles riots, and this animosity was only further heightened after the effects of the riots. Historian Timothy Tangherlini—a professor from the University of California, Los Angeles—describes that there was widespread arson, violence, and looting taking place in the South Central District which impacted many individuals living in Koreatown.¹² While the impacts were tragic to Koreans after the LA riots, the tensions amongst multiple ethnic groups before the riots contributed to the destruction of South Los Angeles and instigated the start of the Los Angeles Riots in 1992. During a Cable News Network interview, Bernard Parks, the former LAPD deputy chief officer, mentioned that Koreans, “were providing a service, but that personal relationship was missing.” Parks argues that African Americans perceive the presence of Koreans as intrusive because they created businesses, became landowners, and primarily came to America to strive economically which displaced black communities of their economic

⁹ Hernandez, Salvador. “Daryl Gates: Blunt, controversial, loyal – Orange County Register.” *Orange County Register*, 27 April 2010, <https://www.ocregister.com/2010/04/27/daryl-gates-blunt-controversial-loyal/>. Accessed 2 September 2023.

¹⁰ Wallace, Carvell. “The Unrest That Led to the L.A. Riots, Twenty-Five Years On.” *The New Yorker*, 28 April 2017

¹¹ Christopher, Warren. *Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department*. N.p., DIANE Publishing Company, 1998.

¹² Tangherlini, Timothy R. “Remapping Koreatown: Folklore, Narrative and the Los Angeles Riots.” *Western Folklore*, vol. 58, no. 2, 1999, pp. 149–73. JSTOR, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1500164>. Accessed 20 Dec. 2023.

opportunities.¹³ This caused tensions between communities because Koreans would become more employed which allocated fewer resources for Blacks according to the 1980 census.¹⁴ Thus, this angered Black communities because their economic opportunities were deprived, which developed tensions that fueled Blacks to start the Los Angeles Riots in 1992. Additionally, Attorney David Kim believes Koreans had a less tangible relationship towards Los Angeles whereas Blacks have had a long history of their upbringings while living in Los Angeles.¹⁵ Kim argues that “African-Americans are the ones who have paved the road for the Korean merchants to come and do business in this country.” which highlights the tensions between Blacks and Asians.¹⁶ These tensions between black residents of Los Angeles and the Korean Merchants occurred due to miscommunication because of language barriers.¹⁷ This is especially seen after Latasha Harlins was shot to death in a Korean-American store.¹⁸ Furthermore, attorney and political activist Angela Eunjin Oh argues that the burning, looting, and theft of the Los Angeles Riots in Koreatown was attributed to the poor race relations between African Americans and Koreans. During the riots, 2,500 small, Korean, immigrant-owned businesses suffered a mass economic catastrophe.¹⁹ Thus, because the majority of the rioting occurred in Koreatown, this serves to symbolize the primary example of how the tensions accumulating between Koreans and Blacks led to the catastrophic aftermath of the Los Angeles Riots.

Nevertheless, the inconsistencies, discrimination, and discrepancies in the Justice System, were the biggest contributors to the Los Angeles riots. On April 29, 1992, the same day as the LA riots, the highly anticipated results of the Rodney King trial also occurred. All the police officers who beat Rodney

¹³ Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

¹⁴ Hu, Arthur. “Us and Them.” *New Republic*, vol. 206, no. 22, June 1992, pp. 12–14. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=f49025ac-e57b-3872-8c5d-52e3bf6f6204.

¹⁵ “Race and Rage: The Beating of Rodney King.” *CNN Live Event/Special*, June 2012. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=3eb0dd23-9560-3708-ab67-19dc89bf85d3.

¹⁶ “Race and Rage: The Beating of Rodney King.” *CNN Live Event/Special*, June 2012. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=3eb0dd23-9560-3708-ab67-19dc89bf85d3.

¹⁷ “Race and Rage: The Beating of Rodney King.” *CNN Live Event/Special*, June 2012. *EBSCOhost*, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=3eb0dd23-9560-3708-ab67-19dc89bf85d3.

¹⁸ Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

¹⁹ Oh, Angela E. “An Issue of Time and Place: The Truth Behind Korean Americans’ Connection to the 1992 Los Angeles Riots.” *Asian American Policy Review*, vol. 19/20, Jan. 2010, pp. 39–48. *EBSCOhost*

King were not convicted and were set free without any repercussions.²⁰ However, this court case had numerous discrepancies, the first being the location of the trial—Simi Valley City.²¹ Although the beating of Rodney King occurred in the inner city of Los Angeles, the trial took place nowhere near South Los Angeles but instead took place in a suburban neighborhood that has a highly white concentrated population of 79.9%.²² This made the jury inconsistent as there were ten white jury members, one Hispanic, an Asian, and zero African American representation.²³ This makes sense due to the location of the court being predominantly white but the accident took place in South Los Angeles which had a mainly Hispanic and African-American demographic.²⁴ The location of the court was favorable for the police officers who beat Rodney King, which created a biased Jury and questionable verdict, making the process of the Judicial system problematic and an instigator for the Los Angeles Riots. Judicial System discrepancies are also seen elsewhere such as the People vs. Soon Ja Du trial. Soon Ja Du is a Korean immigrant who was charged with first-degree murder after the death of an African-American teenager, Latasha Harlins. Du believed Latasha Harlins was robbing her store, and shot her fatally. Soon Ja Du was guilty of only murder based on self-defense and was left free with only probation.²⁵ In both these court cases, the location of the Rodney King Court Case was prejudiced against blacks with the distribution of Jury not representing any Black representation and the Soon Ja Du court case highlights how even after the death of Latasha Harlin, there were minimal repercussions for the murder of Blacks. The Judicial System perpetuates discrimination against blacks and warrants the question of to what extent were these discrepancies the biggest contributor. Nevertheless, before the Rodney King Incident, courts of law were prejudiced against the black population and provided groups to protest during the Los Angeles Riots in 1992.

²⁰ Oh, Angela E. "An Issue of Time and Place: The Truth Behind Korean Americans' Connection to the 1992 Los Angeles Riots." *Asian American Policy Review*, vol. 19/20, Jan. 2010, pp. 39–48. EBSCOhost,

²¹ Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

²² Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

²³ Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.

²⁴ Mitchell, John L. "In South L.A., a population shift." *Los Angeles Times*, 14 September 2008, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-2008-sep-14-me-southla14-story.html>. Accessed 15 September 2023.

²⁵ Oh, Angela E. "An Issue of Time and Place: The Truth Behind Korean Americans' Connection to the 1992 Los Angeles Riots." *Asian American Policy Review*, vol. 19/20, Jan. 2010, pp. 39–48. EBSCOhost,

In conclusion, the prejudice of systematic approach that exists in the Judicial System was one of the key factors that started the Los Angeles Riots. The results of minimal repercussions for the Police Officers in the Rodney King Trial and as well as the Soon Ja Du trial, who was only left on probation after the murder of Latasha Harlins, left black audiences shocked—starting the Los Angeles Riots. Another factor includes tensions between Asians and Blacks. Through Koreans developing more businesses and language miscommunication from migrating in the predominantly black neighborhoods and a large influx of Hispanics replacing previously black communities had developed more tensions, instigating the Los Angeles Riots. Additionally, the LAPD's aggressive methods that often diminished Blacks developed more tensions which is also another factor that contributed to the Los Angeles Riots.

Section 3: Reflection

This investigation has allowed me to become more aware of the methods and challenges that often arise with historians. I've recognized through my own experience with this exploration that historians may deal with confirmation bias, and subjectivity towards the source they utilize. Furthermore, to find sources, they must often go through both online and in-person databases. By doing this, historians may face that they selectively choose other sources while omitting others. This is problematic in society because it provides research conducted to be unethical and misinformation.

Thus, my familial context and Korean heritage before this investigation had already made me develop a personal bias regarding the Los Angeles Riots. My father had immigrated to Los Angeles before the riots and started his first year of high school with lots of tensions with other ethnic groups. His environment would often discuss the riots which anthologized the black population and especially glamorized the Rooftop Koreans. I'd personally be told stories from my father, creating a narrative of the heroism and bravery the Koreans had but unfortunately, these stories I'd often hear would diminish blacks as an aggressive group of people. Before researching, I had a preconceived bias about the events of the LA riots but through researching I gained thorough context for the event. However, I realized this was problematic and ensured that I'd thoroughly investigated key components of what occurred before the rioting, ensuring my research and investigation would be reliable.

Works Cited

- Abu-Lughod, Janet L. *Race, Space, and Riots in Chicago, New York, and Los Angeles*. OUP USA, 2007.
- U.S. Immigration Since 1965 - Impact, Results & Summary*, 5 March 2010,
<https://www.history.com/topics/immigration/us-immigration-since-1965>. Accessed 23 August 2023.
- ABU LUGHOD, Janet L. *New York, Chicago, Los Angeles. America's Global Cities*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999.
- Christopher, Warren. *Report of the Independent Commission on the Los Angeles Police Department*. N.p., DIANE Publishing Company, 1998.
- Crabbe, Richard. "Examining Drug Use by Race." *Free by the Sea*, 3 October 2022,
<https://freebythesea.com/examining-drug-use-by-race/>. Accessed 2 September 2023.
- Fischer, Anne Gray, *The Streets Belong to Us: Sex, Race, and Police Power from Segregation to Gentrification* (Chapel Hill, NC, 2022; online edn, North Carolina Scholarship Online, 18 May 2023), <https://doi.org/10.5149/northcarolina/9781469665047.001.0001>, accessed 6 Mar. 2024.
- "The Emancipation Proclamation | National Archives." *National Archives* |, 28 January 2022,
<https://www.archives.gov/exhibits/featured-documents/emancipation-proclamation>. Accessed 27 June 2023.
- LERMAN, STEVEN A. "From Rodney King to George Floyd." *Newsweek Global*, vol. 176, no. 14, May 2021, pp. 30–31. EBSCOhost,
research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=7621425e-a530-3c8f-9d53-67b6e780336e.
- Newman, John J. *United States History: : Preparing for the Advanced Placement Examination* (2016 Exam). Perfection Learning Corporation, 2016.
- Hernandez, Salvador. "Daryl Gates: Blunt, controversial, loyal – Orange County Register." *Orange County Register*, 27 April 2010,

- <https://www.ocregister.com/2010/04/27/daryl-gates-blunt-controversial-loyal/>. Accessed 2 September 2023.
- Nerad, J. C. (2009). Race, space, and riots in chicago, new york, and los angeles. *African American Review*, 43(1), 213-215. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1353/afa.0.0004>
- Hunt, Darnell M., and Ana-Christina Ramon, editors. *Black Los Angeles: American Dreams and Racial Realities*. NYU Press, 2010.
- Hu, Arthur. "Us and Them." *New Republic*, vol. 206, no. 22, June 1992, pp. 12–14. EBSCOhost, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=f49025ac-e57b-3872-8c5d-52e3bf6f6204.
- JONES, CHARISSE. "Old Memories Confront New Realities in South L.A. : Neighborhood: Some blacks adjust, others leave what was once the core of the African-American community." *Los Angeles Times*, 17 February 1992, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1992-02-17-mn-1711-story.html>. Accessed 25 August 2023.
- Kennedy, Channing. "Daryl Gates: The Thin Blue Line Between Personal and Structural Racism." *Colorlines*, 16 April 2010, <https://colorlines.com/article/daryl-gates-thin-blue-line-between-personal-and-structural-racism/>. Accessed 2 September 2023.
- "Race and Rage: The Beating of Rodney King." CNN Live Event/Special, June 2012. EBSCOhost, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=3eb0dd23-9560-3708-ab67-19dc89bf85d3.
- Mitchell, John L. "In South L.A., a population shift." *Los Angeles Times*, 14 September 2008, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-2008-sep-14-me-southla14-story.html>. Accessed 15 September 2023.
- Newman, John J. *United States History: : Preparing for the Advanced Placement Examination (2016 Exam)*. Perfection Learning Corporation, 2016.

Rainey, James. "Final Suit Over LAPD's Use of Chokehold Settled." *Los Angeles Times*, 29 September 1993, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1993-09-29-me-40159-story.html>. Accessed 15 March 2024.

Wallace, Carvell. "The Unrest That Led to the L.A. Riots, Twenty-Five Years On." *The New Yorker*, 28 April 2017, <https://www.newyorker.com/culture/culture-desk/the-unrest-that-led-to-the-l-a-riots-twenty-five-years-on>. Accessed 18 March 2024.

Oh, Angela E. "An Issue of Time and Place: The Truth Behind Korean Americans' Connection to the 1992 Los Angeles Riots." *Asian American Policy Review*, vol. 19/20, Jan. 2010, pp. 39–48. EBSCOhost,

Woo, Elaine. "Daryl F. Gates dies at 83; innovative but controversial chief of the LAPD." *Los Angeles Times*, 8 March 2014, <https://www.latimes.com/local/obituaries/la-me-daryl-gates17-2010apr17-story.html>. Accessed 29 August 2023.

Wilkerson, Isabel. *The Warmth of Other Suns: The Epic Story of America's Great Migration*. New York: Random House, 2010.